HIJAB. HATE. AND STATE: The fight for human rights. And feminist churn within the Muslim world

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In 1953, Sanam Naraghi Anderlini's grandmother taught herself how to write and penned powerful advice to her daughter, "You have to be able to earn your own living and not rely on men." Anderlini, an Iranian peace activist and founder of the International Civil Society Action Network, uses this example as a reminder of what Muslim women once stood for—independence and being able to make their own life choices.

Sheeba Aslam Fehmi, an Islamic feminist, agrees that the idea of feminism for Muslim women is often put in a western context rather than within an Islamic cultural framework. For her, the controversy over the hijab in India is "an artificial and political question". Afghan political leader Fawzia Koofi has personally been on the receiving end of Muslim patriarchy, having to walk to school in her childhood dodging bullets by the Taliban, and still receiving numerous death threats for her work to support women's education and rights. "In Afghanistan, our story is beyond just the Hijab. Yes, the women want to wear the scarf but they also want to go to office, to go to school, to go to the university, they want to be able to be respected as a human being," she says.

There is hope. Take the example of Harvard graduate Ruha Shadab, who chose to give up a promising medical career to make a social change for Muslim women. Her foundation LedBy is the first leadership incubator to promote the professional development of Muslim women. Anderlini, too, believes Iran's recent 'Women, Life, Freedom' movement is a watershed moment, "This is the first time we are seeing men standing with women from different generations asking for women's rights." Fehmi, too, feels the future looks brighter than ever before for Indian Muslim women. A lot still needs to be done though. For Koofi, it's a global fight to stand against the forces that misinterpret religious and cultural beliefs to suppress women and deprive them of their rights. ■

The untapped potential of Muslim women continues to be a challenge in India... and if all of us aren't contributing to the most of our potential, it's holding [our] countries back

RUHA SHADAB
Founder, LedBy Foundation

Photographs by **BANDEEP SINGH**